

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 23 Summary

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In this lesson, we take a deeper look at time expressions in Spanish using the verbs *hacer*, *desde*, and *desde hace*. These expressions can be tricky for English speakers because they don't translate word-for-word. The key is to learn the patterns and understand what each one is used for. Once you learn the formulas, you'll be able to express how long something has been happening, when something started, and how long ago something happened—with confidence.

Spanish Master Course – Lesson 23

Time Expressions with *hace*, *desde*, and *desde hace*

1. Using *hace* + time expression + verb in the preterite

This formula is used to express how long ago something happened.

Formula:

hace + time expression + preterite verb

(You can also flip it: preterite verb + *hace* + time expression)

Examples:

- *Fui a la tienda hace dos años.* = I went to the store two years ago.
 - *Llegaron hace tres años.* = They arrived three years ago.
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2. Using *desde*

Desde means *since* and is used to express the point in time when something began (and is still ongoing).

Formula:

present tense verb + *desde* + specific point in time

Examples:

- *Vivo aquí desde 2020.* = I've been living here since 2020.

- ¿Desde cuándo estás aquí? = Since when have you been here?
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3. Using *desde hace*

This expression is used to show how long something has been happening, focusing on the duration.

Formula:

present tense verb + desde hace + time expression

Examples:

- *Trabajo aquí desde hace cinco años.* = I've been working here for five years.
 - *Vivimos en esta casa desde hace diez años.* = We've been living in this house for ten years.
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4. Alternate Structure: *Hace + time expression + que + present tense verb*

This is another common way to express how long something has been going on.

Formula:

hace + time expression + que + present tense verb

Examples:

- *Hace cinco años que trabajo aquí.* = I've been working here for five years.
- *Hace diez años que vivimos en esta casa.* = We've been living in this house for ten years.

This construction translates literally as: *It makes five years that I work here*, which sounds odd in English, but is perfectly natural in Spanish.

5. Alternate Structure: *Llevar + time expression + gerundio*

This is a very natural way to express duration and is often preferred in conversation.

Formula:

llevar (conjugated) + time expression + gerundio (-ando / -iendo)

(Literally: to carry X amount of time doing something)

Examples:

- *Llevo cinco años trabajando aquí.* = I've been working here for five years.
 - *María lleva diez años viviendo en esa casa.* = María has been living in that house for ten years.
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Regional Note:

In Mexico and parts of Latin America, *tener* may be used instead of *llevar* with this structure.

Examples:

- *Tengo cinco años trabajando aquí.* = I've been working here for five years.
 - *María tiene diez años viviendo en esa casa.* = María has been living in that house for ten years.
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Key Takeaway:

Spanish offers multiple ways to talk about time expressions. Learn the formulas and don't try to force a direct translation from English. Choose one pattern, practice it until it's second nature, then add the others over time. These structures appear frequently in conversation, so the more exposure you get, the easier it will become.